

The Case Against Car-Free Downtowns

Proposals to ban private cars from downtown cores sound progressive, but for mid-sized cities they are a mistake. Unlike New York or Copenhagen, most mid-sized American cities lack the transit density, housing density, and population to make a car-free core work. A ban would drain businesses, burden the people with the fewest options, and push activity to the suburbs.

Transit is the core problem. In a typical mid-sized city, buses run every 30 to 60 minutes and many routes stop by early evening. The American Public Transportation Association reports that fewer than 5 percent of commuters in metros under one million use transit at all. Removing cars without first building service simply removes access.

Businesses feel it first. When Kalamazoo, Michigan, created one of the nation's first pedestrian malls in 1959, it was celebrated, but many of the more than 180 pedestrian malls built in the U.S. during the following decades were later reopened to traffic after vacancies climbed. Research from the University of Virginia found that most failed pedestrian malls were in cities with populations under 100,000 and without a strong tourist draw.

Supporters point to Pontevedra, Spain, and argue that a car-free core raised business and cut deaths. That success is real, but Pontevedra is compact, dense, and walkable by design, with most residents living within a short walk of the center. That is not the shape of most American mid-sized cities, which sprawled outward after 1950. Importing the policy without the urban form is setting it up to fail.

A better approach is to calm traffic rather than ban it: wider sidewalks, lower speed limits, protected bike lanes, and weekend pedestrian-only events. These capture most of the safety and livability gains without cutting off shoppers and workers who have no alternative to driving.

Cities should earn car-free streets by building the transit and housing that make them work. Banning cars first gets the order backwards.

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